

FLIGHTLESS BIRDS



FLYING IS A VERY USEFUL WAY of moving, but it does have drawbacks. It uses a lot of energy, and it is possible only for animals with a light body. During the course of evolution, some birds have given up flight and the problems it brings. Instead, they run, or, as is the case with penguins, they swim; some can move extremely fast. There are about 40 species of flightless birds alive today, including kiwis, emus, and the world's biggest bird, the ostrich. Many more flightless species, including some record-breaking giants, existed in the past, and some of today's species are also in danger of extinction.

Kiwis

These medium-sized birds are found only in the forests of New Zealand. Their wings are only about 5 cm (2 in) long, and their body is covered with a unique plumage that looks like hair. Kiwis are nocturnal and because they have poor eyesight, they find food mainly by smelling it.



Strong legs with large feet.

This egg is shown in proportion to the kiwi above.



Probing beak

The kiwi has nostrils at the tip of its long, curved beak, instead of near its head. It uses its beak to find food on the forest floor.

Kiwi egg

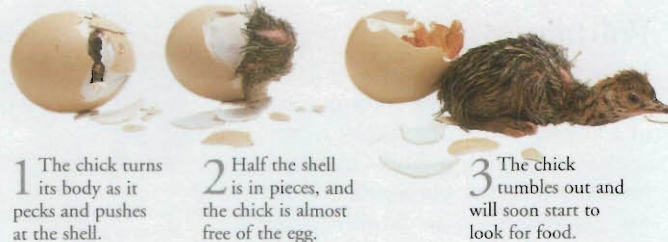
The kiwi's egg is 13 cm (5 in) long, and is a quarter of the female's weight. Relative to her body, the female kiwi lays the largest eggs of all birds.

Ostrich

The ostrich is the world's largest bird. It can run at up to 65 kmh (40 mph), and uses its speed and stamina to outdistance most of its enemies. An ostrich's feet have two toes, and each toe ends in a large claw. If an ostrich is cornered, it uses these claws as deadly weapons to defend itself.

Hatching

The shell of an ostrich egg is thicker than a china mug, but not as hard. The young ostrich breaks out by kicking and pecking at the shell.



1 The chick turns its body as it pecks and pushes at the shell.

2 Half the shell is in pieces, and the chick is almost free of the egg.

3 The chick tumbles out and will soon start to look for food.

Sensory, whisker-like feathers at the base of the beak

Hard "helmet," or casque

Rheas escape from danger by running away.

Cassowaries

These large, flightless birds live in dense forests in northern Australia and New Guinea. They use their claws as weapons and have been known to kill people.



Rheas

There are two species of rheas, both of which live on the open plains in South America. Young rheas have bright stripes, but the adults are grayish-brown.



Emus

Found only in Australia, emus are the second largest birds in the world, after the ostrich. Emus live in large flocks and wander long distances in search of food. They can cause problems on farms by raiding crops.

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Long neck with sparse feathers

Weak, fanlike wings used in courtship rituals.



Females are slightly smaller than males, with brown plumage instead of black.

Two large clawed toes on each foot

Ostrich crèche

Young ostriches are guarded by an adult male. Several families of chicks gather together, forming a group called a crèche.

OSTRICH

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Struthio camelus*

ORDER Struthioniformes

FAMILY Struthionidae

DISTRIBUTION Tropical western and eastern Africa, and southern Africa

HABITAT Savannah and semi-desert

DIET Fruit, seeds, leaves, small animals

SIZE Height up to 2.4 m (8 ft); weight up to 154 kg (340 lb)

LIFESPAN About 30 years